

Alex Rivera

Backend Engineer — distributed systems & developer tooling

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SUMMARY

Backend engineer with six years building high-throughput services. Comfortable owning a system end to end, from schema design through on-call. Recent focus on cutting latency and cost in data-heavy pipelines.

EXPERIENCE

Northwind Data

Mar 2022 – Present

Senior Software Engineer

Austin, TX

- Rebuilt the ingestion pipeline around a partitioned queue, raising sustained throughput from 4k to 26k events/second.
- Cut p99 API latency by 63% by replacing per-request joins with a materialised read model.
- Led the migration of 40+ services to structured logging, reducing mean incident triage time from 22 to 8 minutes.
- Mentored three engineers; two were promoted within the year.

Cobalt Systems

Jul 2019 – Feb 2022

Software Engineer

Remote

- Designed and shipped the public REST API now used by 1,200+ integration partners.
- Introduced contract testing across service boundaries, eliminating a recurring class of deploy-time regressions.
- Reduced cloud spend 18% by right-sizing workloads and consolidating idle clusters.

PROJECTS

queuelite — Author

2023 – Present

- A dependency-free job queue for Postgres, 2.1k stars.
- Exactly-once delivery via advisory locks and a visibility timeout, with no external broker.

EDUCATION

University of Texas at Austin

2015 – 2019

B.S. Computer Science

Austin, TX

- **Grade:** GPA 3.8/4.0
- **Coursework:** Distributed Systems, Databases, Compilers.

PUBLICATIONS

- A. Rivera, J. Okonkwo. *Backpressure Without Tears: Practical Flow Control in Event Pipelines*. USENIX SREcon Americas. 2024.

SKILLS

Languages : Python, Go, TypeScript, SQL

Infrastructure : PostgreSQL, Kafka, Redis, Kubernetes, Terraform

Practices : Distributed systems design, Observability, CI/CD, Incident response